International Journal of Emergency Mental Health and Human Resilience, Vol. 15, Nos. 2 & 3, pp. xxx-xxxx © 2013 Chevron Publishing ISSN 1522-4821

# Resilient Leadership and the Organizational Culture of Resilience: Construct Validation

George S. Everly, Jr,
The Johns Hopkins University School of Medicine,
The Johns Hopkins Bloomberg School of Public Health,
Loyola University Maryland

Kenneth J. Smith
Department of Accounting and Legal Studies
Salisbury University

Rachel Lobo
Loyola University Maryland

*Abstract: Political, economic, and social unrest and uncertainty seem replete throughout the world. Within the United States, political vitriol and economic volatility have led to severe economic restrictions. Both government and private sector organizations are being asked to do more with less. The specter of dramatic changes in healthcare creates a condition of uncertainty affecting budget allocations and hiring practices. If ever there was a time when a "resilient culture" was needed, it is now. In this paper we shall discuss the application of "tipping point" theory (Gladwell, 2000) operationalized through a special form of leadership: "resilient leadership" (Everly, Strouse, Everly, 2010). Resilient leadership is consistent with Gladwell's "Law of the Few" and strives to create an organizational culture of resilience by implementing an initial change within no more than 20% of an organization's workforce. It is expected that such a minority, if chosen correctly, will "tip" the rest of the organization toward enhanced resilience, ideally creating a self-sustaining culture of resilience. This paper reports on the empirical foundations and construct validation of "resilient leadership." [International Journal of Emergency Mental Health and Human Resilience, 2013, 15(Nos. 2 & 3), pp. xxx-xxx].*

*Key words: resilience, leadership, crisis leadership, resilient leadership, culture of resilience.*

## The Problem

Uncertainty in United States healthcare, real estate, and stock markets make planning and resource allocation challenging at best for many organizations. Domestically, the wars in Afghanistan and Iraq are winding down. This nation is waiting with great anticipation for the return of thousands of military members and their subsequent reunification with family and friends. In the celebration of this reunification, we would be remiss if we did not acknowledge the challenges that will be inherent in any such process. Many returning veterans will be seeking employment in an economy that is suffering high unemployment, historic credit restrictions, and an existing workforce that is reluctant to retire at previously expected age milestones. From a mental health perspective,

George S. Everly, Jr, PhD, ABPP is professor of psychology and associate professor of psychiatry and behavioral sciences. Kenneth J. Smith, DBA, CPA is professor and chairman of accounting. Rachel Lobo is in the department of psychology, Loyola University Maryland. Correspondence regarding this article should be directed to Dr. Everly at geverly@jhsph.edu.

many veterans are returning with posttraumatic stress disorder, posttraumatic depression, and traumatic brain injury, as well as severe physical injuries and disabilities. Psychiatrically, many of them will go undiagnosed and untreated until they experience significant adjustment problems with the family, the workplace, or perhaps the law enforcement system. From a systems' perspective, uncertainty and crisis (or even the threat thereof) stifles innovation, is an impediment to investment, and fosters a hording mentality, both personally and institutionally. From a personal perspective crisis creates fear, unrest, and paralyzes inclinations to act, or leads to the opposite course, i.e., impulsive, often regretful, actions largely because it threatens a core human need…the need for safety. The resultant toxic environment may erode organizational, community, and personal health. As dismal as this might sound, not every organization, community, or person is adversely affected by the toxicity of uncertainty and manifest crisis. Some individuals seem resilient in such circumstances, thus they are minimally affected. Others manifest such resilience that they seem to actually prosper in adversity. In times of prosperity, there is little motivation to study human resilience, but during times of uncertainty, crisis, and adversity the motivation is substantial.

## A Solution

We have previously published on the personal characteristics of highly resilient people (Everly, McCormack, & Strouse, 2012). In this paper we shall examine resiliency at the systems' level with the intention of creating an organizational culture of resilience engendered through leadership. This construct and approach we call "resilient leadership."

## Resilience Defined

Human resilience may be thought of as the ability to positively adapt to, withstand, and/or rebound from significant adversity and distress. Bonnano (2004) defines resilience as the ability of adults to maintain relatively stable and healthy levels of psychological and physical functioning after having been exposed to potentially disruptive or traumatic events. Bonnano suggests that factors such as hardiness, self-enhancement, repressive coping (emotional dissociation), and positive emotions may undergird effective resilience.

Haglund, Cooper, Southwick, and Charney (2007) postulate six primary factors that may protect against, and aid in, recovery from extreme or traumatic stress:

1. actively facing fears and trying to solve problems;
2. engaging in regular physical exercise;
3. being optimistic;
4. following a moral compass;
5. promoting social support, nurturing friendships, and seeking role models; and
6. being open minded and flexible in the way one thinks about problems, or avoiding rigid and dogmatic thinking.

Resiliency is not a monolith, however. It occurs on a continuum.

## The Johns Hopkins Model of Resiliency

In an effort to provide clarity to the rapidly growing field of resilience studies, efforts from the Department of Psychiatry at The Johns Hopkins University School of Medicine yielded an integrative model of human resilience. The model contributes heuristic value to the construct of resilience and is referred to as the Johns Hopkins Model of Resistance, Resilience, and Recovery. The Hopkins' model serves to advance the field by recognizing the importance of putting resilience on a continuum, and by separating out the notion of protective immunity (resistance) from the notion of reactive resilience as a form of rebound (Kaminsky et al., 2007; Nucifora, Hall, & Everly, 2011).

## Organizational Culture of Resilience (and Resistance)

While it is important to identify and foster factors that promote personal resilience (Everly, McCormack, & Strouse, 2012), a public health and an organizational development perspective would dictate the search for, and promotion of, community and organizational resilience (Everly, et al, 2011). The organizational culture of resilience is one in which there is an atmosphere, or organizational climate, wherein growth is promoted, support is abundant, and crisis is viewed as an opportunity. Simply stated, the culture of resilience is an environment wherein resistance and resilience are not only fostered but are the core fabric of the culture itself.

It matters not whether the "organization" is a non-profit or a for-profit organization. The organization could be a volunteer group, a sports team, or even a family. Regard-

less of its constituency or its purpose, a culture of resiliency would be deemed valuable. Historically, the family system has been an excellent platform upon which to study and promote resilience. It can serve as a proxy for the study of communities and organizations of all kinds. McCubbin and McCubbin (1988) argued that there are four things resilient families do that less resilient families fail to do:

They believe in the family unit. They believe in the importance of family cohesion. They have high family identity.

They celebrate key family events, such as birthdays and anniversaries. They create and uphold rituals and routines.

They believe in their ability to support, advocate for, and protect one another. They are optimistic about their ability to achieve family goals (family efficacy).

Finally, they possess good family communications (McCubbin et al., 1996; Everly, 2009).

Most would agree that an organizational culture of resilience represents a most desirable climate to promote. So the remaining question is this: how might one create such a climate? We propose it is achieved through leadership - "resilient leadership" (Everly, Strouse, Everly, 2010). Resilient leadership practices serve as the catalyst that inspires others to exhibit resistance and resilience and to exceed their own expectations. It helps create a culture of resilience wherein adversity is seen as opportunity and support is omnipresent. Based upon the observations of Malcom Gladwell (2000) and consistent with his "Law of the Few," resilient leaders can create the "tipping point" that changes an entire culture. Using a military model, the tipping point for changing the culture would be having roughly 20% of the population of a group practicing resilient leadership, although this might vary according to the organization. But for those 20% to have a maximum impact they must be unique. They should meet three criteria, i.e., the three Cs: 1) have credibility, 2) be information conduits (usually frontline supervisors), and 3) be willing to promote the success of others via collaboration. Other authors have written of similar concepts, but not fully integrated the role of leadership to promote resilience, and even less foster the creation of a culture of resilience.

## Transformational Leadership

The concept of transformational leadership was initially introduced by James MacGregor Burns. According to his theory, transformational leadership can be seen when, "leaders and followers make each other advance to a higher level of morale and motivation." (Bass & Riggio 2006, p.4). That being said, it is a leadership style that leads to positive changes in those who follow, and through the strength of their vision and personality, transformational leaders are able to inspire followers to change expectations, perceptions, and motivations to work towards common goals. Later, researcher Bernard M. Bass expanded upon Burns' original ideas to develop what is today referred to as Bass' Transformational Leadership Theory. In Bass' view, "transformational leadership can be defined based on the impact that it has on followers. They garner trust, respect and admiration from their followers." (Bass et al. 2006, p.7). He believed that these leaders focused on being energetic, enthusiastic and passionate, and were leaders concerned with helping every member of the group succeed to their fullest potential. Additionally, Bass also suggested that there were four different components of transformational leadership: intellectual stimulation, individualized consideration, inspirational motivation, and idealized influence.

Intellectual stimulation recognizes that without creativity and innovation, long-term success is impossible. The leader encourages followers to explore new ways of doing things and new opportunities to learn.

Individualized consideration involves offering support and encouragement to individual followers. "In order to foster supportive relationships, transformational leaders keep lines of communication open so that followers feel free to share ideas and so that leaders can offer direct recognition of each follower's unique contributions." (Bass et al. 2006, p.10). Coaching, mentoring and advising are all examples of individualized consideration because they require a basic understanding of employee needs and motivations.

Inspirational motivation suggests that transformational leaders have a clear vision that they are able to articulate to followers. "Success in this dimension requires a certain level of charisma in order to develop influence into action." (Bass et al. 2006, p.19). Leaders create an atmosphere of teamwork that encourages co-workers to action in order to realize the larger company vision. Inspirational motivation encourages employees to take real action to make the vision a reality.

Idealized influence, in its most basic form, means becoming a role model. Since followers trust and respect their

leaders, they emulate this individual and internalize his or her ideals to make their own. "Sometimes referred to as "walking the talk," idealized influence hearkens back to Max Weber's original research on charismatic heroes." (Bass et al. 2006, p.20).

## In Extremis Leadership

In extremis leadership is discussed by Thomas Kolditz (2007) based on work by Kolditz and Donna Brazil. It is a leadership skill that purports to demonstrate "authentic leadership." Authentic leaders are confident, optimistic, and possess high moral character and ethical reasoning. These leaders provide purpose, motivation, and decisive direction "in extremis" (highly stressful) conditions. They are most likely to create loyalty, obedience, admiration, and respect. Authentic leaders seem to exert much of their effectiveness by making their followers feel safe. They ease fear and provide hope for those who follow; safety is based in trust, and trust in honor and integrity.

Authentic leaders have a willingness to share the same or more risk as their followers. Authentic leaders appear to be intrinsically motivated leaders. Pay should take a backseat to other more important concerns. People who live and choose to work in dangerous environments learn to love life more than the next person simply because they seem to live in a world where value is only loosely attached to material possessions and wealth.

Lastly, authentic leaders must be highly competent in order to gain the subordinate's trust and loyalty. According to Kolditz (2007), authentic leadership emphasizes the development of hope, resilience, and optimism within a highly ethical perspective. That being said, "To be a leader is not to hold down a position or perform a job: it is to develop a character that is inextricably linked to giving purpose, motivation, and direction to others" (Kolditz, 2007, p.71). Kolditz recommends that we go beyond skill-focused leader training, and use a more inspirational, more spiritual approach. Leaders like these need to work on putting themselves last and their followers first, and being able to lead their people in a comprehensive, modest manner, while achieving the mission.

## Crisis Management Leadership

Crisis management, a leadership technique begun by Ian Mitroff, is the process by which an organization deals with a major event that threatens to harm the organization, its stakeholders, or the general public. As discussed in his own book, *Crisis Leadership: Planning for the Unthinkable,* Mitroff (2006) talks about how managers, consultants, and researchers have traditionally focused on problems of financial performance and growth, but have paid little attention to the effective management of corporate crises. He claims that, "The study of crisis management originated with the large scale industrial and environmental disasters in the 1980s" (Mitroff, 2006, p.10). Crisis management involves dealing with threats before, during, and after they have occurred. It is also a discipline within the broader context of management consisting of skills and techniques required to identify, assess, understand, and cope with a serious situation, especially from the moment it first occurs to the point that recovery procedures start. The purpose of this leadership skill is to argue that no one can prevent all disasters, but organizations can adopt an approach for managing them more effectively in a timely manner.

As Mitroff portrays, the essential phases of crisis management in his model are as follows: detection, crises, repair, and assessment. "Detection stands for the organization's early warning systems that include computerized control systems, monitoring systems, management systems, and environmental scanning systems that scan both external and internal signals for impending crises" (Mitroff, 2006, p.22). Crises emphasize the second point in his model that no organization can prevent every crisis from occurring. In terms of dealing with a crisis, "Prevention and preparation take the form of safety policies, maintenance procedures, environmental-impact audits, crisis audits, and worker training" (Mitroff, 2006, p.34). Phase three of the model focuses on guiding the organization back to recovery, and repairing any damages the company had to endure due to the causes of the crisis. Last, but not least, management draws up assessments based on the previous crises, and prepares the company for a more proactive approach to addressing any upcoming issues they encounter. Mitroff makes it clear that, "first and perhaps most important is that most crises are preceded by a string of early warning signs that are key in preventing any sort of problem the organization has to endure" (Mitroff, 2006, p.47).

## Resilient Leadership Data

Integrating the preceding postulations on human resilience and leadership, the "resilient leadership" construct was postulated by Everly (Everly, 2009; Everly, Strouse &

Everly, 2010) as an effective and efficient means to create the culture of resilience. Initially based upon scholarly reviews as noted above, the core presiding "covenants" of resilient leadership were described as "strength and honor." Seeking to add greater specificity to the construct of covenants and an empirical foundation for the construct itself, we obtained and analyzed data (available at C-SPAN websites) pertaining to C-SPAN-initiated surveys of historical scholars wherein the scholars were asked to rate the 41 presidents of the United States in 2000 and the 42 presidents in 2009 on overall leadership and nine core constituents of leadership effectiveness and a 10th element of crisis leadership. We omitted the 10th as we saw it as a component of one of the core nine.

## METHOD

In 2000, the C-SPAN described its methodology as follows:

- C-SPAN conducted a Survey of Presidential Leadership, in which historians & viewers participated online. The survey rated 10 qualities of presidential leadership established by our advisory team, including each president's effectiveness within the context of our nation's changing expectations of the presidency…The C-SPAN Survey of Presidential Leadership was crafted by a team of four historians and academics who have been deeply involved in the American Presidents series...The four survey advisors devised a survey which asked participants to use a one ("not effective") to ten ("very effective") scale to rate each president on ten qualities of presidential leadership… The survey was sent by mail in December to 87 historians and other professional observers of the presidency… Fifty-eight agreed to participate. Survey responses were tabulated by averaging all the responses in any given category for each president."

In 2009, C-SPAN repeated the survey. It was described as follows:

- "Surveys were distributed to 147 historians and other professional observers of the presidency, drawn from a database of C-SPAN's programming, augmented by suggestions from the academic advisors. Sixty-five agreed to participate. Participants were guaranteed that individual survey results remain confidential. Survey responses were tabulated by averaging all responses in a given category for each president."

It is an empirical truism that reliability is the sine qua non of validity. The 2000 and 2009 C-SPAN results were most highly reliable for the top five presidential leaders. Thus we chose to analyze the C-SPAN data with the goal of revealing the leadership constituents that were deterministic of the highest rankings and most reliable findings. In essence we sought to discover what leadership behaviors determined effective leadership. To do so we simply averaged the scores obtained by the top five leaders for the 2000 and 2009 surveys on the nine core constituents of leadership. We drew a cutting line between the fourth and fifth constituent, as the first four constituents were highly reliable across surveys and had universal applicability, whereas the fifth through eighth constituents possessed situational but not universal applicability.

## FINDINGS

The results of our analyses are reported in Table 1 below.

TABLE 1.
Ranking and Mean Values of Leadership Behaviors in C-SPAN 2000 and 2009 Surveys

| Leadership Behavior | 2000 Score | 2009 Score |
|---|---|---|
| Performance (Action) | 90.6 | 89.8 |
| Vision/Agenda (Optimism?) | 90.2 | 88.2 |
| Moral Authority (Ethics?) | 88.2 | 85 |
| Public Persuasion (Communications) | 87.4 | 84.6 |
| International Relations | 86.2 | 83.6 |
| Administrative Skills | 78 | 78 |
| Economic Management | 77.8 | 74 |
| Relations with Congress | 71.6 | 71.8 |
| Pursuit of Justice and Equality | 73.4 | 71.2 |

## DISCUSSION

Our analyses yielded evidence that the most important and universally applicable leadership behaviors were Performance, what we shall refer to as decisiveness and action; Vision/Agenda, what we see as active optimistic vision; Moral Authority, what we refer to as honesty, ethics, and morality; and Public Persuasion, what we refer to as effective communications.

It is interesting to note that Crisis Leadership scored 89 in the 2009 survey. We did not include that in our analyses as we saw it as a covariate and redundant to performance. It is nevertheless interesting to note that performance in crisis appears to be an important aspect of perceived leadership effectiveness.

These findings appear consistent with our covenants of strength and honor and serve to provide greater granularity by operationalizing "strength" as 1) performance, and 2) optimistic vision (who would follow a pessimistic leader?), while operationalizing "honor" as 1) honesty and morality, and 2) effective communications. Truncating further, perhaps we could say effective and resilient leadership, as defined herein, consists of optimistic action and open, honest communications.

### Summary

The preceding impressions may be more heuristic than determinative; nevertheless they may be worthy of consideration. The empirical foundations serve as a form of construct validation, as well.

The immediate future does not appear to hold any "quick fix" nor any spontaneous healing for a world that, at times, seems out of control. We believe a "culture of resilience" is, if not requisite, certainly a first step. This culture we believe is best achieved and maintained through training "first line supervisors" to practice and model resilient leadership as defined herein.

## REFERENCES


Bass, B.M., & Riggio, R.E. (2006). *Transformational leadership*. Mahwah, NJ: L. Erlbaum.

Bonnano, G.A. (2004). Loss, trauma, and human resilience: Have we underestimated the human capacity to thrive after extremely aversive events? *American Psychologist, 59* (1), 20-28.

Everly, G.S., Jr. (2009). *The resilient child*. NY: DiaMedica

Everly, G.S., Jr., Strouse, D.A., & Everly, G.S., III (2010). *The secrets of resilient leadership*. NY: DiaMedica

Everly, G.S., Jr., McCormack, D., & Strouse, DA (2012). Seven characteristics of highly resilient people. *International Journal of Emergency Mental Health,* 14(2), 137-143.

Everly, G.S., Jr., Davey, J., Smith, K, Lating, J., & Nucifora, F. (2011). A defining aspect of human resilience in the workplace: A structural modeling analysis. *Disaster Medicine and Public Health Preparedness, 5*, 98-105.

Gladwell, M. (2000). *Tipping point*. NY: Little Brown.

Haglund, M., Cooper, N., Southwick, S., & Charney, D. (2007). 6 keys to resilience for PTSD and everyday life. *Current Psychiatry*, 6, 23-30.

Kaminsky, M.J., McCabe, O.L., Langlieb, A., & Everly, G.S., Jr. (2007). An evidence-informed model of human resistance, resilience, & recovery: The Johns Hopkins' outcomes-driven paradigm for disaster mental health services. *Brief Therapy and Crisis Intervention*, 7, 1-11.

Kolditz, T.A. (2007). *In extremis leadership: Leading as if your life depended on it.* NY: Jossey-Bass Publications.

McCubbin, H.I. and McCubbin, M.A. (1988). Typologies of resilient families: Emerging roles of social class and ethnicity. *Family Relations*, *37*(3), 247-254.

McCubbin, M.A., & McCubbin, H I. (1996). Resiliency in families: A conceptual model of family adjustment and adaptation in response to stress and crises. In H. I. McCubbin, A. I. Thompson, & M.A. McCubbin, *Family assessment: Resiliency, coping and adaptation--Inventories for research and practice* (pp. 1-64). Madison, WI: University of Wisconsin System.

Mitroff, Ian. (2006). *Crisis leadership: Planning for the unthinkable.* John Wiley and Sons Publications.

Nucifora, F., Hall, R., & Everly, G.S., Jr., (2011). Reexamining the role of the traumatic stressor and the trajectory of posttraumatic distress in the wake of disaster. *Disaster Medicine and Public Health Preparedness,* 5 (supplement 2), S1-4.